

Tips & Tricks

SECRETS THAT KEEP YOU AHEAD IN THE RACE

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VIRTUALDUB



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VirtualDub is used to encode videos. Video encoding isn't as difficult as it is often made out to be.

VirtualDub is a very popular software for the purpose. Encoding your videos brings down file sizes of your gaming videos, home videos recorded on your camcorder, etc. We look at some useful features in VirtualDub, as well as some finer tweaks. VirtualDub can be downloaded from, as expected, www.virtualdub.org.

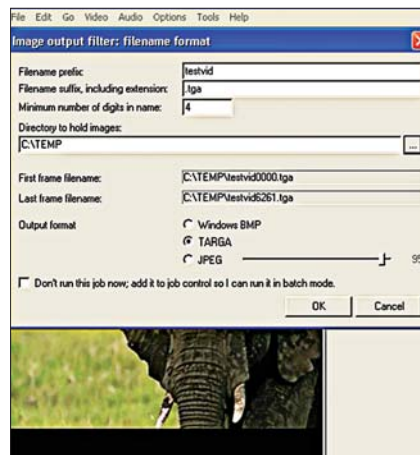
Opening And Saving Rendered Image Sequences

When animations are rendered through 3D modelling software, for example, they can be rendered as a sequence of images. They are generally easier to

handle in composition software. Using formats like TGA, for example, can store much better quality as well.

It is generally assumed that VirtualDub only allows importing and exporting of videos. But actually, VirtualDub can open up sequences of images as long as they are named with the standard convention, for example, RENDER001.TGA, RENDER002.TGA, RENDER003.TGA and so on. To open a sequence, select File > Open video file. Select the first file of the image sequence and click Open. The entire image sequence will be loaded as an animation. You can now do the same set of tasks with it like with any video file.

In the same way, a video can be exported as a sequence of images. When you have a video opened in VirtualDub, select File > Save image sequence. Enter a filename prefix, the location



VirtualDub can import and export videos as sequence of images

where you want the sequence to be saved, and the format you want to save it in. If you choose JPEG, you are allowed to set compression levels, though TGA is preferred for best quality.

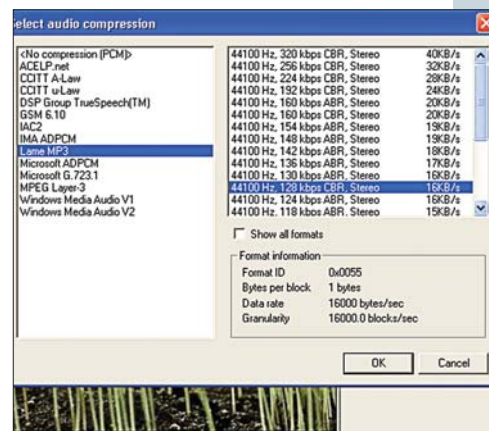
Encoding MP3 Audio Streams

Anyone using VirtualDub for the first time will immediately notice that audio encoding bit rates for MP3 will be limited to a maximum of 56 Kbps, whereas MP3 allows much higher bitrates. 56 Kbps is really low; to make sure you are limited to this bitrate, check by selecting Audio > Compression after switching to Full Processing mode from the same Audio menu.

Downloading a third-party MP3 codec such as LAME will allow you to encode at any bitrate up to 320 Kbps. You can download the LAME ACM codec from <http://rarewares.org>. Unzip



Installing the LAME MP3 Codec



Once installed, LAME MP3 Codec gives you a much wider range of bitrates

the file to a suitable location. Go to that folder, right-click on the LameACM.inf file and select Install. Click on Continue Anyway when prompted. Start VirtualDub and under the Audio Compression settings, a LAME MP3 entry should have appeared. This allows the complete range of bitrates.